

TWO TO FOUR CAT BURGLARS

TUMBLER

a clockwork heist for two to four cat burglars



· CLICK · SNEAK · PAWS · STASH ·



WARNING:

CHOKING HAZARD

— Small parts. Not for children under 3 yrs.

A clockwork heist for two to four cat burglars

Turn the locks, fill your satchel and get home before Bartholomew wakes.

THE PRINTED RULEBOOK

Rules · illustrated examples · A-Z Almanac

THE GAME AT A GLANCE

How the game works

You are a cat burglar in a house full of turning locks. Bring home the best haul before the watchdog ends the night.

Your goal

Collect loot in the maze and carry it out through **your own cat flap**. Loot is safe only once you stash it in your den in the lid.

The cat with the most points in its den wins. A shiny is worth 3 points, your favourite kind is worth 5, and the Golden Fish is worth 7. The Fish is valuable, but it does not guarantee a win.

You take turns in rounds. Everyone gets one turn, then the watchdog dial counts down and the first-paw token passes on. Finish the round in which the Fish is stashed or the dial reaches the awake dog. Then score (p. 11).

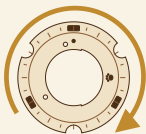
Find your way

Meet the pieces	3-4
Set the table	5-6
Take your turn	7-8
Use your abilities	9
The Golden Fish & pounce	10
The night & scoring	11
One turn, all four steps	12
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Every turn, in this order

1

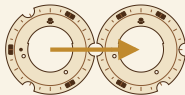
CLICK



Turn one nearby wheel one notch. You must click, even if you stay put.

2

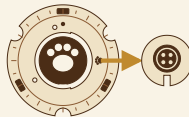
SNEAK



Move up to two steps through open passages. You may move fewer, or none.

3

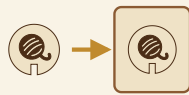
PAWS



Resolve the loot on the wheel where you stop. Do not collect along the way.

4

STASH



If you finish outside, put everything you carry into your den.

Example. Marmalade needs yarn, but the nearest yarn is on the wrong side of the house. Opening a route home can be more useful than racing for another disc.

First game? Read pages 2-12 in order and leave the turn example open. Later, look up a bold term in the Almanac. Its alphabetical entries and page references settle the details. For any difference with the lid reminder, follow this book.

COMPONENTS · 1 OF 2

The four cats

Four cats, four favourite shinies. Everyone can see what each cat loves.



Marmalade

1 cat + 1 bar foot
Cat flap 1



Yarn: 5 points



Soot

1 cat + 1 bar foot
Cat flap 4



Bell: 5 points

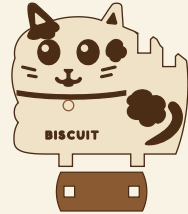


Domino

1 cat + 1 bar foot
Cat flap 2



Button: 5 points



Biscuit

1 cat + 1 bar foot
Cat flap 5



Bottle cap: 5 points

The names and favourite symbols are on the **den cards engraved inside the lid**. These are part of the tray, not loose cards. Each cat has two carrying slots in its back: its satchel.

13 loot discs



2 × Yarn

Shiny



2 × Button

Shiny



2 × Bell

Shiny



2 × Bottle cap

Shiny



2 × Cucumber

The dial drops 1



2 × Treat

Wake an ability



1 × Golden Fish

7 points; fills both slots



Common back

Paw side = face down

Count the haul. 8 shinies + 2 cucumbers + 2 treats + 1 Golden Fish = 13. The common back shown above is the reverse of a loot disc, not an extra piece. Only shinies and the Fish score, and only in your den.

COMPONENTS · 2 OF 2

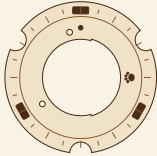
The board, the wheels and the tiles

19 maze wheels

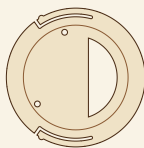
6 inner + 12 outer + 1 vault. Each wheel is a face glued to a detent disc. The vault is the centre wheel; the watchdog dial is separate.



A wheel, assembled. The cutaway under the well lets you tip a loot disc up.



Face: gates, wards and well.

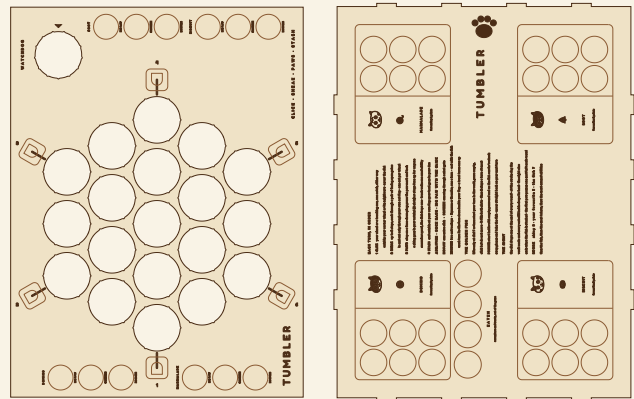


Detent disc: two spring fingers.

Inner faces have **one dot**; outer faces have **two dots**. Keep them in their own rings. The vault has two opposite gates. Some outer wheels have four gates; the rest of the ordinary wheels have three.

One box, two trays

The **base is the board**. The open lid is the **den tray**, with 4 den cards, the engraved rules and 4 eaten-stack spaces. The board has 4 ability racks, one per cat.



Left: board layer. Right: den tray. Racks and den cards are engraved, not loose pieces.



1 watchdog dial
Face + 13-stop disc.



1 first-paw token
Marks who starts the round.

12 ability tiles · three per cat



4 × Big Paw



4 × Squeeze



4 × Zoomies



Spent side

Start with the three different abilities face up on each active cat's rack. When you use one, flip it in place to the sleeping-cat side. The rack shows exactly what is ready.

SETUP · THE TABLE

Lay out the table

Place the lid beside the base, with both interiors facing up. This is a four-cat table; use the same maze for every player count.

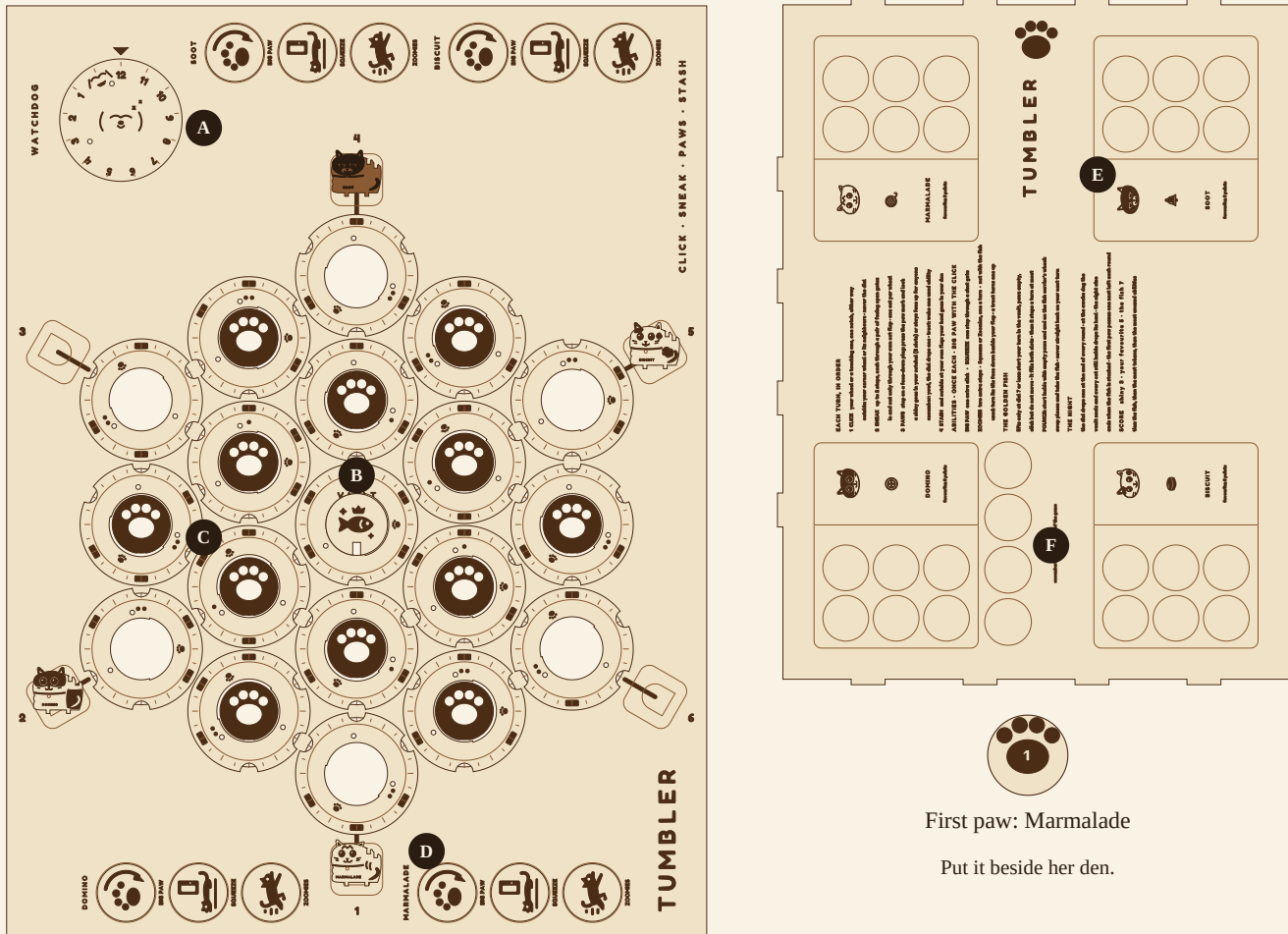


Figure 1. The real board and tray, with pieces added. Wheels are shown in one possible arrangement; shuffle and turn them for your game. The tray is drawn smaller to leave room for labels.

A Watchdog

Start at 12; at 10 only in the one-cat-each quick game.

B Vault

Golden Fish face up in the centre.

C Hidden loot

Six inner wells + six outer edge wells.

D Cats & racks

Cats outside; all three abilities face up.

E Den cards

Your portrait marks your safe haul.

F Eaten stack

Start empty. Treats and cucumbers go here.

Read the flaps on the wood. Marmalade uses 1 (bottom), Soot 4 (top), Domino 2 (lower left), Biscuit 5 (upper right). Flaps 3 and 6 are unused. “Top” and “bottom” here match Figure 1.

SETUP · READY TO PLAY

Setup, step by step

- 1

Choose your cats

Use the cats in the table below. With three or four players each controls one cat. **With two players each controls two:** Marmalade and Domino against Soot and Biscuit, taking turns in seat order and adding both dens together. For a quicker two-player game, play one cat each (Marmalade and Soot) and start the dial at 10. Take each cat’s three ability tiles and find its den card in the lid.
- 2

Mix the maze

Lift out the 18 ordinary wheels. Shuffle the six one-dot wheels within the inner ring and the twelve two-dot wheels within the outer ring. Return them face up. Keep the vault in the centre. Turn **all 19 wheels** to random click stops.
- 3

Hide the loot

Set the Fish aside. Mix the other 12 discs with their paw backs up, without looking. Put one in each of the six inner wells and each of the six outer edge wells. Leave all six corner wells empty. Put the Fish face up in the vault.
- 4

Place the cats

Place each active cat outside its own numbered flap. Put Big Paw, Squeeze and Zoomies face up on that cat’s named rack. Leave unused cats and their tiles aside. Empty the dens and eaten stack.
- 5

Set the watchdog

Turn the dial so the starting number meets the fixed triangular pointer on the board: **12**, or 10 in the one-cat-each quick game. The awake-dog position means zero.
- 6

Give Marmalade first paw

The youngest player takes Marmalade. Sit in the cat order below, with Soot to Marmalade’s left, then Domino, then Biscuit when used. Marmalade starts round 1. Put the first-paw token beside her den.

Players	Cats in seat order · own flap	Dial starts
2	Marmalade · 1 → Soot · 4 → Domino · 2 → Biscuit · 5, two cats each (quick game: Marmalade → Soot)	12 (quick game 10)
3	Marmalade · 1 → Soot · 4 → Domino · 2	12
4	Marmalade · 1 → Soot · 4 → Domino · 2 → Biscuit · 5	12

Pass first paw each round

The holder takes the first turn. Continue left until each cat has had **one** turn. Resolve the dial and the end of the round (p. 11). If the game continues, pass first paw one seat left.

Example. With three cats, round 1 is Marmalade → Soot → Domino. Round 2 is Soot → Domino → Marmalade. Round 3 is Domino → Marmalade → Soot.

Every game is a new layout

This shuffled setup is the standard game, including your first game. There is no separate fixed opening. Change wheel locations only during setup, within their rings; during play, you rotate them.

A shut route is allowed at the start. Your mandatory Click, and later your abilities, help you find a way in.

YOUR TURN · 1 & 2

Click, then Sneak

1 Click · required

Turn **one wheel by one notch** (one sixth of a turn), clockwise or counter-clockwise. Choose the wheel you stand on or any wheel touching it. If you are outside, choose your own corner wheel or one touching that corner.

You may click a wheel carrying a cat, and you may click the vault if it is in reach. The cat and loot stay on that wheel. **Never use Click on the watchdog dial.**

Click even if no useful passage opens. You cannot save this click for after moving. Big Paw can add a second click here (p. 9).

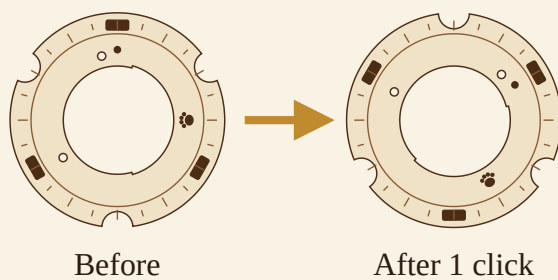
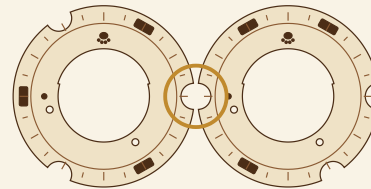


Figure 2. One notch changes every gate on that wheel. A click does not move your cat to a different wheel.

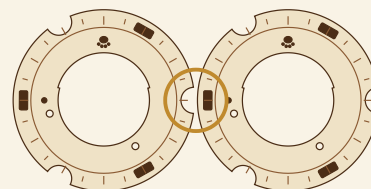
Example. Marmalade is outside flap 1. She may turn its corner wheel or any of its three neighbours. She cannot click a distant wheel just because it blocks her planned route.

2 Sneak · up to 2 steps

A step moves from one wheel to a touching wheel through a **passage**: both facing gates must be open. Two gate notches meeting across the gap make a visible **keyhole**. A dark, uncut **ward** closes that side.



OPEN · two facing gates



CLOSED · a ward blocks the way

Figure 3. Look at the two sides that face each other. One open gate is not enough. The brass circle marks the crossing.

Move zero, one or two steps. Entering or leaving through your own flap costs one step and needs its corner wheel's outward gate open. Other flaps are walls to you.

Cats block. You may neither stop on nor pass through an occupied wheel. The only exception is a legal pounce on the Fish carrier (p. 10). Loot alone does not block movement.

Example. Entering your corner wheel is step 1. Going on to a neighbouring wheel is step 2. You resolve loot only on that final wheel.

Trapped? Make your Click, then stay if you cannot or do not want to move. You still resolve Paws. Being trapped gives no free ability or extra click.

YOUR TURN · 3 & 4

Paws, then Stash

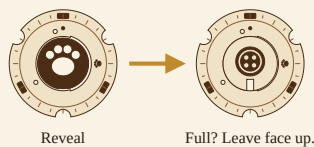
3 Paws · resolve your well

If you finish on a wheel with a face-down disc, **reveal it even with a full satchel**. Press at the wheel's paw mark, pinch the raised edge and turn it over. Lift your cat briefly if needed.

Resolve only your final wheel, even after staying. Never collect along the way.

- **Shiny:** take it if you have a free slot. Otherwise leave it face up in the well.
- **Cucumber:** lower the dial by 1 immediately; put the disc in the eaten stack.
- **Treat:** restore a spent ability as described on p. 9; put the disc in the eaten stack.
- **Golden Fish:** use its special lifting rule on p. 10.

A face-up shiny is taken by any cat ending there with room. Cucumbers and treats always resolve, even with two shinies or the Fish in your satchel. They never take a slot.



Example: Soot reveals a button with a full satchel. It stays face up. Domino can later take it with a free slot: 5 points if brought home.

The satchel · two slots

Carry up to two shinies, one disc in each slot. Fit a disc's rim slot over a slot in your cat's back. Their cuts overlap in a **cross-halving joint**, holding the disc upright. Lift it straight up to remove it.



Figure 4. Two separate discs ride in Marmalade's two slots. Their rim cuts lock over the cat's back; do not force or twist them.

The Fish uses **both slots as a rule**, even though it is one physical disc. You cannot carry a shiny with it.

Keep carried loot visible to everyone. You cannot freely drop or exchange a shiny. The one exception is leaving one shiny in the vault as you lift the Fish (p. 10). The Fish cannot be put down.

4 Stash · finish outside

If you finish your Sneak outside your own flap, move **all** carried loot to your den, face up. Stashing costs no extra step. Your haul is safe there and cannot be stolen.

You may return on a later turn. Crossing outside and returning inside in the same move does not stash.

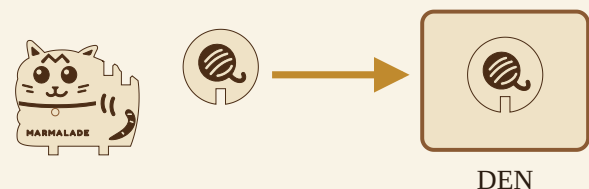


Figure 5. Marmalade brings yarn home: 5 points safely stashed.

ABILITIES

The three abilities

Every cat starts with the same three abilities. The face-up tiles on your rack are ready; sleeping cats are spent.



Big Paw · during Click

Make **one extra click** before you move. Use the same wheel or a different eligible wheel, in either direction. Both clicks use the reach from your starting location. You may use Big Paw while carrying the Fish.



Squeeze · during Sneak

Cross **one blocked edge** as one of your two steps, even if one or both facing gates are shut. It can also open your way through your own closed flap. You still cannot cross an occupied wheel except for a legal pounce.



Zoomies · during Sneak

Add **two steps**, for up to four this turn. Each crossing still needs an open passage, and entering or leaving your flap still costs a step. Resolve Paws only where you finish.

Using an ability

Turn an ability face down when you use it. Use each ready ability at most once in its phase. You may combine **Big Paw with Squeeze or Zoomies**. You cannot combine Squeeze and Zoomies in one turn.

With the Fish, use at most two movement steps and neither Squeeze nor Zoomies. A treat found later in Paws cannot send you back to Click or Sneak.

Example. Domino uses Big Paw to click twice, then Squeeze to cross one shut edge in a two-step move. Domino cannot add Zoomies to that move.

Treats wake an ability

When you find a treat, turn **one spent ability of your choice** face up. If all three are ready, the treat does nothing. Either way, put it in the eaten stack; you cannot carry or save it.

Example. Big Paw and Zoomies are asleep. Biscuit eats a treat and chooses to wake Big Paw. Zoomies stays asleep.



Big Paw · spent



Squeeze · ready



Zoomies · ready

Figure 6. Leave every tile in its named rack space, so a sleeping-cat back still identifies the spent ability.

THE GOLDEN FISH

The Golden Fish

The Fish is worth 7 points in your den. Lifting it, carrying it and keeping it each have their own rules.

Lift it from the vault

You lift the Fish only if **all three** are true at the start of your turn:

1. The dial is **7 or lower**.
2. You are already on the vault, with the Fish still in its well.
3. You carry **zero or one shiny**.

Make your normal one-notch Click, but **do not move or use an ability** on this lifting turn. When all three conditions are met, you lift the Fish this turn. In Paws, take the Fish. If you carried one shiny, leave it face up in the vault in the Fish's place. With two shinies, you cannot lift it.

Arriving at the vault is not enough: you must wait until a later turn that starts there. You may move through or wait on the vault while the dial is above 7; the lock restrains the Fish, not your cat.

Example. At dial 7, Soot starts in the vault with a bell. Soot clicks once, stays, leaves the bell in the well and takes the Fish. Another cat can later collect that bell.

Carry it home

The Fish fills both satchel slots. On later turns you have up to two steps, with **no Squeeze or Zoomies**. Big Paw remains available. You cannot put the Fish down or take a shiny alongside it.



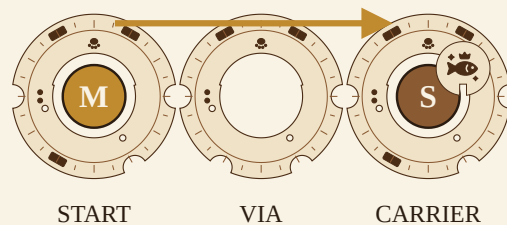
Pounce · steal the Fish

To pounce, start your turn **inside the maze with an empty satchel**, then move onto the Fish carrier's wheel. The path must be legal. You may use Big Paw and either Squeeze or Zoomies to reach the carrier.

Your move ends there. Take the Fish and move the other cat to **the wheel where you started this turn**. It is a swap, even if your route took several steps. The other cat is now empty-handed.

A pounce costs no extra step or ability and does not lower the dial. The carrier need not be trapped. You cannot pounce from outside, through a blocking cat, without moving, or with a shiny in your satchel.

The victim cannot pounce back on **that taker** on the victim's very next turn. After that turn the restriction expires. If a different cat takes the Fish first, the victim may pounce on that different carrier.



After: Soot at START; Marmalade + Fish at CARRIER.

Figure 7. M = Marmalade; S = Soot. Swap with the starting wheel, not the last wheel crossed. The arriving cat stops with the Fish.

After a pounce: resolve Paws on the carrier's wheel. A cucumber or treat still takes effect; a shiny stays face up because the Fish fills your satchel. The displaced cat does not resolve loot or take an extra turn.

THE NIGHT & THE SCORE

The night ends

The watchdog counts down

Bartholomew’s dial has thirteen positions: 12 down to 1, then the **awake dog** (zero). Turn it toward lower numbers. Never wrap from the dog back to 12.

End of each round	2 cats	3–4 cats
Fish still in vault	–1	–1
Fish has been lifted	–2	–1

Each cucumber also lowers the dial by 1 immediately, in addition to the round’s drop. Lifting or pouncing on the Fish causes no immediate drop.

Finish the current round

If the Fish is stashed, or a cucumber brings the dial to zero, **each cat still waiting in this round gets its normal turn**. Then apply the round’s dial drop, stopping at zero, and resolve the end:

1. **If the Fish is in a den:** the heist ends. Score the dens.
2. **Otherwise, if the dial is zero:** Bartholomew wakes and the vault seals. Every cat still inside loses everything it carries. Score the dens.
3. **Otherwise:** pass first paw and begin the next round.

Example. A cucumber takes the dial from 1 to zero on the first turn of a round. The other cats still take their turns and can stash. If one stashes the Fish, resolve the Fish ending; otherwise the dog takes every unbanked haul.

Scoring

3	5	7
shiny	your favourite	Golden Fish

Carried loot and loot left on the board score **nothing**. Cucumbers, treats and ability tiles score no points. Your favourite is fixed: Marmalade yarn; Soot bell; Domino button; Biscuit bottle cap.

Example den	Points
Marmalade: yarn, yarn, bell	5 + 5 + 3 = 13
Soot: bell, Fish	5 + 7 = 12
Domino: button, cap	5 + 3 = 8

Marmalade wins this example. Stashing the Fish ends the night; it does not award the win by itself.

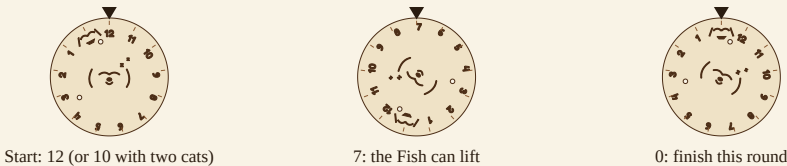
If points are tied

Compare only the tied cats, in this order:

1. The cat with the Fish **in its den** wins.
2. Then, the cat with more discs in its den wins.
3. Then, the cat with more ready (face-up) abilities wins.
4. If still tied, the tied cats share the win.

The Fish is one disc when counting discs.

Same-round finish. If the Fish is stashed and the dial reaches zero in the same round, the Fish ending takes priority. In either ending, only loot already in dens scores.



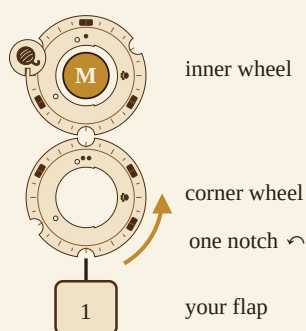
Read the number or awake-dog symbol at the fixed pointer, not the sleeping dog in the centre.

A TURN, FROM START TO FINISH

Marmalade brings yarn home

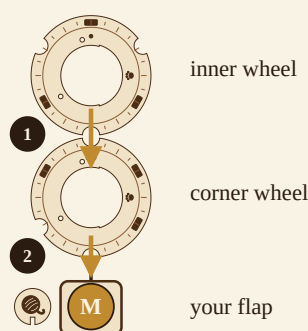
Marmalade begins on the inner wheel next to flap 1's corner wheel. She carries one yarn. The corner wheel's inward and outward gates are both shut. Her abilities are all ready.

1 • Click



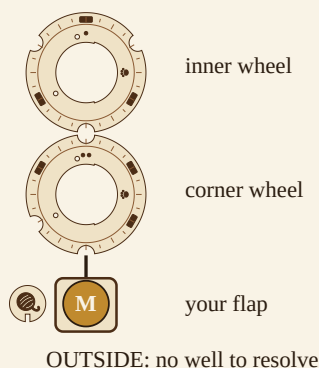
Marmalade turns the touching corner wheel one notch counter-clockwise. Its gates now face the inner wheel and flap 1. This uses her normal Click; she keeps Big Paw ready.

2 • Sneak



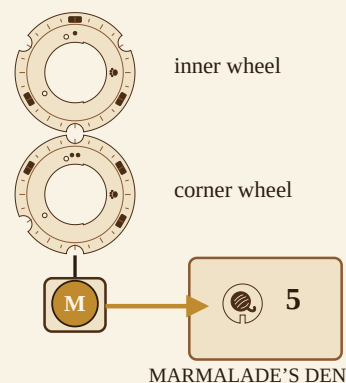
She takes two steps: first through the open passage to the empty corner wheel, then out through her own open flap. The small circles count the two crossings.

3 • Paws



She finishes outside, so there is no well to resolve. She collected nothing while crossing the corner wheel. Her yarn is still in her satchel.

4 • Stash



She moves the yarn into her den, face up: 5 points because yarn is her favourite. Her satchel is empty. Next turn she can try to enter again.

What if a cat occupied the corner? Marmalade could not enter or pass through it. She could stay and resolve Paws on her current wheel, or choose another legal destination. Carrying yarn prevents her from pouncing even if that cat holds the Fish.

Figure 8. These are actual inner and outer wheel outlines. M marks Marmalade's position; brass arrows show actions. The rest of the maze is omitted. Before the click, the corner face is one notch clockwise from its position shown in the four frames.

Almanac

Find the term, read its ruling, then follow the page reference for the complete rule or illustrated example.

Abilities

Flip a ready tile to spend it. Big Paw combines with either Squeeze or Zoomies; those two cannot combine. Timing and recovery: p. 9.

Alarm

Another name for the watchdog dial; see p. 11.

Awake dog

The dial's zero position. Finish the current round before resolving the end. Fish-stashed takes priority; see p. 11.

Bar foot

The narrow base supporting each cat on the board.

Bartholomew

The watchdog on the dial, not a separate pawn.

Bell

Soot's favourite shiny. Each bell in Soot's den scores 5; in any other den, 3.

Big Paw

During Click, add one click within normal reach. Usable while carrying the Fish, but not on its lifting turn. See p. 9.

Biscuit

Cat at flap 5, used with four players or in the two-player team game. Favourite: bottle cap.

Blocked edge

A crossing with one or both gates shut. Squeeze permits one such crossing, but cannot bypass an occupied wheel. See p. 7.

Board / box

Base: maze, dial and four racks. Lid: den tray with four engraved den cards and eaten spaces. See p. 4.

Bottle cap

Biscuit's favourite shiny; two discs in the game.

Button

Domino's favourite shiny; two discs in the game.

Cat flap

Only your own flap admits you. Crossing costs one step and needs its outward gate open, unless using Squeeze. Assignments: p. 6.

Click

First phase, mandatory: one notch either way on your wheel or a neighbour. Outside: your corner or its neighbours. Never the dial. See p. 7.

Corner wheel

One of six outer wheels pointing toward flaps. Starts empty; stays in play even when its flap is unused.

Cross-halving

The disc's rim slot overlaps the cat's back slot to hold loot upright. Lift straight up to remove. See p. 8.

Cucumber

Lower the dial by 1 immediately, even with full paws. Put it in the eaten stack. At zero, finish the current round.

Den / den card

Your named lid area. All stashed loot stays here, face up and safe. Only this loot scores. Six circles do not limit capacity.

Detent

The mechanism holding wheels at click stops. One maze click is 60 degrees.

Dial

The watchdog countdown. Starts at 12; 10 in the one-cat-each quick game. See p. 11.

Domino

Cat at flap 2. Favourite: button.

Drop

See Leaving loot, p. 14.

Eaten stack

Lid spaces for resolved treats and cucumbers, out of play.

Edge wheel

One of six outer wheels between corners. Each starts with hidden loot.

Almanac, continued

Face down / face up

Loot: paw back is down, symbol is up. Abilities: sleeping cat is spent, ability symbol is ready. Always reveal loot at your final wheel.

Favourite

Your public shiny, shown on your den card. Worth 5 in your den instead of 3. Cat-to-shiny guide: p. 3.

First paw

The youngest player takes Marmalade, who starts round 1. Each cat gets one turn, then pass the token one seat left if play continues. See p. 6.

Fish

See Golden Fish below. Worth 7 in a den; nothing while carried.

Gate

A cut notch in a wheel edge. A normal crossing needs two facing open gates. See Figure 3, p. 7.

Golden Fish

At dial 7 or less, start in the vault with at most one shiny: click once, stay and lift. Leave that shiny behind. Full rules: p. 10.

Haul

The loot you have collected.

Heavy

The Fish fills both slots and bars Squeeze and Zoomies.

Hub

Another name for a wheel's central well.

Inner wheel

One of the six one-dot wheels around the vault. Starts with hidden loot. Shuffle only within the inner ring at setup.

Keyhole

The visible gap made by two facing gate notches: an open passage. See Figure 3, p. 7.

Leaving loot

No general voluntary drop or exchange. Leave a revealed shiny when full, or exchange one for the Fish when lifting it. Never put the Fish down.

Lid

The den tray during play. Keep it beside the base, inside up.

Lock

See Time lock, p. 15, or Board, p. 13 for the turning maze.

Loot

13 discs: eight shinies, two cucumbers, two treats and one Fish. Full picture inventory: p. 3.

Marmalade

Cat at flap 1, favourite yarn. Starts round 1.

Neighbour

A touching wheel, regardless of gates. Click reach uses neighbours; movement uses open passages.

Night

One game. Round drop: 1, or 2 with two cats after Fish lifts. Cucumbers add immediate drops. Final round and ending priority: p. 11.

Occupied wheel

A cat blocks stopping and passage except by a legal pounce. See p. 10.

Outer wheel

One of twelve two-dot wheels: six corners and six edges.

Outside

Your own flap space beyond its corner wheel. Finish here to stash all carried loot.

Passage

Two facing open gates between touching wheels. See Figure 3, p. 7.

Paws

Resolve only your final wheel's loot, even after staying. See p. 8.

Plug

Another name for a loot disc.

Pounce

Start inside empty-handed; arrive on the Fish carrier. Stop, take the Fish; send the victim to your starting wheel. Next-turn pounce-back restriction: p. 10.

From racks to Zoomies

Rack

Three named spaces holding your ability tiles. Keep each tile in its space; all racks are public.

Ready

An ability showing its face-up symbol, available to use.

Round

One turn per active cat, from first paw continuing left. Then lower the dial and check endings. See p. 11.

Satchel

Two slots hold two shinies or the Fish alone. Empty paws means no carried loot. See p. 8.

Score

Den only: shiny 3, favourite 5, Fish 7. Tie: Fish in den, more den discs, more ready abilities, then share the win. See p. 11.

Seat order

Marmalade, Soot, Domino, Biscuit; omit inactive cats. First paw changes the starting cat, not the cycle or last tie-break.

Setup

Shuffle wheels within their rings and fill wells as on p. 6.

Shiny

Yarn, button, bell or bottle cap; two of each. Worth 3, or 5 to its favourite cat, once stashed.

Sneak

Move zero, one or two steps, altered by an ability if used. Flap crossings count. Resolve only the destination's loot. See p. 7.

Soot

Cat at flap 4. Favourite: bell.

Spent

An ability showing a sleeping cat, unavailable until a treat restores it.

Squeeze

One blocked crossing in two steps, including your flap. No blocking cat except by pounce; no Zoomies or carried Fish. See p. 9.

Stash

Finish outside your own flap: transfer all carried loot to your den. No extra step. Passing outside does not stash.

Step

One crossing between neighbours, or your corner and own flap. No jumps or outside travel between flaps.

Time lock

The Fish lifts only at dial 7 or lower. The vault can be entered earlier.

Trapped

No usable exit. Still Click and resolve Paws. No free ability or bonus action.

Treat

Turn one spent ability of your choice face up. All ready? No effect. Eaten either way; cannot save it. See p. 9.

Turn

Click → Sneak → Paws → Stash. One per cat each round.

Unused flap

No cat enters or exits here, but its corner wheel remains in the maze.

Variable setup

Shuffle within rings and turn every wheel randomly, every game. See p. 6.

Vault

Centre wheel with two opposite gates. May be clicked within reach and entered before dial 7. Fish rules: p. 10.

Ward

An uncut, dark-marked side of a wheel, closing that direction.

Watchdog

Bartholomew's countdown dial; see p. 11.

Well

Central hollow for loot and a cat's foot.

Wheel

Face bonded to detent disc. Turn only in Click, including Big Paw.

Yarn

Marmalade's favourite shiny.

Zoomies

Add two steps, for up to four. No Squeeze in that move; unavailable while carrying the Fish. See p. 9.

QUESTIONS AT THE TABLE

Frequently asked

May I click the wheel another cat stands on?

Yes, if it is your wheel or a touching wheel within your Click reach. Rotate the wheel without changing which wheel holds the cat or loot.

Can Squeeze cross two shut gates at once?

Yes, if they face each other across one edge. That is one blocked crossing. It cannot cross two separate blocked edges or any occupied wheel except by a legal pounce.

Can I Squeeze with the Fish?

No. You may Squeeze to pounce and acquire it at the end of that move. Once you carry it, neither Squeeze nor Zoomies is available.

A treat, but nothing is spent?

Eat it anyway. It goes to the eaten stack with no effect. You cannot save it or take an extra action later in that turn.

What if the dial skips past 7?

At 7 or lower, the Fish is eligible to lift. You do not have to land exactly on 7. The lifting cat must already start its turn in the vault.

May I drop yarn to make room for the Fish?

Only as the one-shiny exchange during a legal lift. With two shinies, first take them home. You cannot drop loot freely around the maze.

What happens when my cat is pushed away?

A pounce puts you on the attacker's starting wheel with an empty satchel. Do not resolve that wheel's loot now. Take your next turn in the normal order.

Can I stay outside all turn?

Yes, but you still make your mandatory nearby Click. Your turn counts for the round. You get no bonus for staying outside.

Can I refuse a face-up shiny?

No. If you finish there with room, take it. If you have no room, it stays face up. A Fish carrier has no room, even with only one physical disc.

Does a den stop at six discs?

No. Its circles are placement guides. Keep extra stashed discs beside that cat's den, clearly separate from the other dens.

Can the last cat still escape at zero?

Yes. Complete all remaining turns in the round. Even a legal Fish lift or pounce may occur at zero. Then resolve the end as on p. 11; there is no new round.

Safety

WARNING: CHOKING HAZARD - Small parts. Not for children under 3 years. Recommended for ages 8 and up. The pieces are laser-cut plywood: check edges for splinters before the first game, keep them away from flame, and do not modify them. Keep this rulebook with the box; the batch code is engraved under the base.

© 2026 Khaero. TUMBLER and its cats are the maker's work; all art is engraved from the game's own cut files.

Care of the wood

Keep the plywood dry. Wipe with a soft dry cloth; do not soak it. Turn wheels gently to their next stop. If one binds, lift it out and check for grit instead of forcing it. Lift loot straight out of the cat slots. Store loose loot flat in the wells, abilities on their racks and cats lying flat before closing the box.

Credits & edition

TUMBLER is the boardgame project's wooden clockwork heist. Game rules, cat art, symbols and mechanical design come from the supplied TUMBLER project files. Manual writing, diagrams and layout: Codex. Illustrations use the actual laser-cut geometry and its 3D renderer.

Print edition · 15 September 2026.

Rules & Almanac for 2-4 individual cats.

Click · Sneak · Paws · Stash

Enjoy the heist.